



arranged in phalanxes – units comprising densely packed rows of troops. They were supported by cumbersome, four-wheeled battle-wagons drawn by onagers (a species related to the horse family).

The Akkadians overcame the Sumerians in around 2350BCE. Under a leader named Sargon, they established the first empire in the Near East, uniting the lands of many city states. Sargon was the first military leader to make use of archers on a large scale, giving the Akkadians a crucial advantage against their less versatile foes.

THE RISE OF BRONZE

In the second millennium BCE, two technical innovations occurred that would shape warfare in the ancient Near East for another thousand years. The first of these was the introduction of bronze. Emerging around 2800BCE, this alloy of copper and tin gave a more durable, sharper edge to weapons than copper alone. Until the technique of bronze-making became widely known, it was prohibitively expensive, but by around 1800BCE, bronze had replaced copper as the predominant metal used for armaments. At about the same



time, horse-drawn chariots with two wheels also appeared, adding a new, highly mobile dimension to warfare.

From around 1300BCE, the Egyptian army – previously an almost entirely infantry force – was radically reorganized under the influence of the Hyksos, a group of foreign invaders who introduced chariots, bronze swords, and metal scale armour. This coincided with an era of Egyptian imperialism, when the armies of pharaohs such as Ramesses II expanded into the Levant and engaged in bitter struggles with rival kingdoms such as the Hittites.

THE AGE OF IRON

By around 1000BCE, iron, being stronger than bronze, was becoming the metal of choice for weapons. It was exploited to lethal effect by the Assyrians (see pp.20–21). During the reign of Tiglath-Pileser III (745–27BCE), Assyria established the world's first standing army, which, when boosted by drafting, numbered over 100,000 men. They wielded the longer swords that iron made possible, and were protected by knee-length metal tunics. Assyrian tactics combined the well-orchestrated push of a heavy phalanx of infantry, with supporting fire from archers and slingers, and assaults by auxiliary units of heavy cavalry and charioteers. With a clear chain of command and a reputation for ferocity and cruelty against their enemies, the Assyrian army was the most formidable fighting force the ancient world had yet produced.

“I tore down... their towns and set fire to them, and turned them into forgotten mounds”

ASSYRIAN RULER SENNACHERIB, ON A REVOLT BY THE CHALDAEANS, 703BCE

▲ AN ASSYRIAN VICTORY

This relief of the Battle of Til Tuba (655BCE) shows the Assyrian archers and spearmen who drove their Elamite foes into the River Uлай, where thousands drowned. The Elamite ruler, Teumanni, was captured and executed.

KEY EVENTS

2600–750BCE

■ **2600BCE** A Sumerian artefact known as the Standard of Ur provides the first depiction of an organized army, with mosaic scenes showing rows of infantry carrying spears and battle-axes, accompanied by onager-drawn battle-wagons. The infantry have no shields or armour.

■ **2000BCE** The first metal swords appear in Mesopotamia as bronze-making spreads and the metal becomes cheaper to produce.

■ **c.1300–1250BCE** New Kingdom Egypt undergoes its period of greatest expansion, while chariot warfare reaches its peak. The Hittite empire disintegrates, after which a period of disorder reigns in the Near East.

■ **c.1000–750BCE** The introduction of iron weaponry aids the expansion of the Assyrian empire. Assyria is the dominant military power in the Near East by 750BCE.